MOUNTAIN REVIEW

OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Volume VI | Issue 1 | Winter 2016

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MOVING MTN. VIEW

Historical Facts & Figures



1852: Mtn. View is founded at a stagecoach stop near where El Camino Real crosses Stevens Creek



1864: The newly completed San Francisco-San Jose railroad bypasses Mtn. View, sprurring the growth of New Mtn. View near the new train depot.



1911: Crisanto Castro Jr. becomes one of the first Mtn. View residents to own a car. (Coincidentally, he probably drove it on multiple streets named for his family, including Crisanto and Castro Streets!)



1933: Moffett Field opens as the Navy's West Coast dirigible air base, home to the USS Macon.



1999: The Santa Clara Valley Transportation Authority completes light rail line to Mtn. View.



2015: Google begins to test drive prototypes of its self-driving cars in Mtn. View.



WINTER EVENT & MEMBERSHIP MEETING:

MOVING MOUNTAIN VIEW

Looking Back at Our Transportation History

"Transportation is the defining theme of Mountain View's history. Many of the town's historical milestones coincide with the introduction of a new mode of transportation—when the Spanish brought horses, California's first stagecoach, the opening of the San Francisco-San Jose Railroad, the first automobiles, airplanes, dirigibles, supersonic jets, and the late twentieth-century light rail projects."

— Mary Jo Ignoffo, *Milestones: A History of Mountain View*

Please join us as we celebrate the history of transportation in Mountain View! From stagecoaches to self-driving cars, transportation has always been an integral part of our city's history. Our program will feature speakers who will share their knowledge of local transportation history, including Rod Diridon Sr., former Santa Clara County Supervisor and emeritus executive director of the Mineta Transportation Institute at San Jose State University.

FREE PUBLIC EVENT — JAN 31, 2016 - 1 PM — ADOBE BUILDING — 157 MOFFETT BLVD.



MOUNTAIN REVIEW

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MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

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In Memoriam

Austin George Spencer
Nov. 8, 1918 -Nov. 19, 2015

Edna Thompson
April 7, 1920 - Dec. 5, 2015

Rembrances on Page 6

News & Notes

President's Message

By Patricia Figueroa
MVHA President

Happy New Year Everyone! The new year always brings us a chance to reflect on the year that's passed and look forward to the year ahead.

In 2015, your Board worked to create compelling events that appealed to a broad spectrum of our membership. In Febuary, we hosted a well-attended panel on the history of the rapidly changing North Bayshore district. In May, we brought back the Roaring 20s with tours of the former Blue & Gold Kennel Club speakeasy. In August, we had one of our most successful BBQs ever, with legendary Disneyland imagineer Bob Gurr as our special guest speaker (and Parisian burgers!). Finally, in November, we gave members a chance to "show and tell" their memories and mementos of Mountain View.

The year 2015 will certainly be tough to top, but we're working on it! Our Winter event on January 31 will focus on the history of local transportation—certainly a relevant topic in our increasingly bustling city. We're excited to have Rod Diridon Sr. as our guest speaker. Mr. Diridon has had a profound impact on Santa Clara Valley's recent transportation history—so much so that San Jose's main Caltrain station was named in his honor in 1994!

Our Spring event on May 1 will celebrate the history of Mountain View's Mexican-American community. We're still in the early stages of planning this event, and we welcome interested members to contact us with their ideas. Summer, of course, will see the return of our annual BBQ on August 7. You can expect the return of Linda's Parisian Burgers! As for our Fall event, well, that's still TBD. We welcome your suggestions!

In closing - I'd like to officially announce that 2016 will mark my last year as President of the MVHA. It's been a pleasure serving in this role over the past five years. Beyond 2016 I will continue to serve the Board in the official role of "Past President." I encourage those interested to consider joining the Board. It's a great team of dedicated volunteers! For more information on our upcoming Board elections, read the message to our members on page 5.

Hope to see you at some of our events in 2016!

Financial Report

By John Figueroa
Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 9/2/15: $13,172.45
- Income: $1,085.15
- Expenses: $1,441.24

Checking Account Balance as of 1/6/16: $12,816.36

Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 9/2/15: $71,714.24
Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 1/6/16: $71,806.01

Immigrant House Update

By Marina Marinovich
MVHA Publicity Chair

Friends of Immigrant House went to the Santa Clara Board of Supervisors' chambers with Rey Rodriguez, the City of Mountain View senior project manager, who gave a presentation to the County of Santa Clara Historical Heritage Commission (HHC). The goal was to have the Commission accept the City of Mountain View's application for the Immigrant House Restoration Project as eligible for $50,000 in funding. If approved, this would eliminate the funding deficit for the proejct.

The HHC was very pleased that the City of Mountain View applied, as the city has never applied before. They unanimously voted on reviewing the grant proposal. After the hearing, the HCC commissioners visited Mountain View's Municipal Operations Center where Immigrant House sits today, followed by a trip to the new park site at 771 N. Rengstorff for inspection. Ultimately, the HHC unanimously approved the grant as eligible for funding! The next step is for the Santa Clara County Board of Supervisors to approve the HHC's recommendation in February 2016.

The Friends of the Immigrant House would like to thank our Mayor, Vice Mayor and Council Members who unanimously voted for the designation of Immigrant House as a historic structure! The Mountain View Parks and Recreation Commission has recommended that the new park be named either Heritage Park or Immigrant Grove Park.

"Window to the World" Debuts on Bryant St.

By Nick Perry
MVHA Newsletter Editor

The long-awaited interactive window display at Bryant Park Plaza (900 Villa Street) in Downtown Mountain View is now in "beta-testing" mode! The display, dubbed "Window to the World" features three interactive screens facing Bryant Street dedicated to the past, present, and future of Mountain View.

For the "yesterday" screen, the building's developer (MVHA member Roger Burnell) worked with MVHA Board Members Marina Marinovich and Nick Perry to create a series of mini-documentaries on Mountain View history. In addition to describing the site's history as the former home of the Pearson House and Immigrant House, mini-documentaries viewable via the screen feature a wide variety of historical topics, from Mountain View High, to Mayfield Mall, to Downtown's early development

Although the finishing touches are still in-progress, next time your Downtown go check it out and let us know what you think!

Arrow Development Documentary Premier

Submitted by Robert Ingle, Nicholas Laschkewitsch, Kimberly Mix and Kris Rowberry
American Coaster Enthusiasts (ACE)



The American Coaster Enthusiasts (ACE) invite you and your family as they premiere their documentary on the history of Arrow Development—a Mountain View manufacturing legend! "The Legacy of Arrow Development" premieres at the Montgomery Theater in Downtown San Jose on Saturday, January 23, 2016.

You may recall the documentary team at the MVHA's Summer BBQ last year, interviewing former Disney Imagineer, Bob Gurr. Well, the film is finally complete, and the team from ACE is very excited to share the complete story of Arrow with everyone.The film follows Arrow from its start out of Hendy Iron Works in Sunnyvale, to its partnership with Walt Disney, groundbreaking work on tubular steel coasters and flume rides, to its several bankruptcies. It also follows several former Arrow employees and how they keep the legacy of the little company from Mountain View alive even to this day.

Tickets are available at: www.SanJoseTheatres.org

Proceeds from the evening benefit American Coaster Enthusiasts, a national 501(c)3 organization.



The Motion-Detecting Interactive "Yesterday" Screen at Bryant Park Plaza's "Window to the World" on Bryant Street.

Street Talk



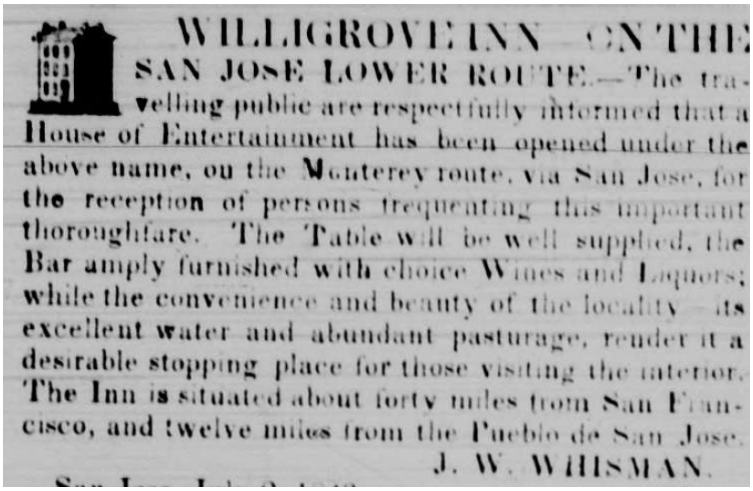
By Nick Perry
Newsletter Editor

As we look forward to our Winter Event focused on the history of transportation in Mountain View, let's learn the history behind a name long associated with transportation in Mountain View-Whisman!

John and Margaret Whisman came to the Santa Clara Valley in 1846 and are considered the first American settlers in the Mountain View area. Shortly after they arrived, they established the Willigrove Inn on the southwest corner of what is now Moffett Field.

In those days, two roads connected San Jose with San Francisco, the Upper San Francisco Road (El Camino Real) and the Lower San Francisco Road, which roughly traces the route of today's Bayshore Highway (US 101). In 1849, John Whisman started one of the first stagecoach lines in California. Whisman's line on the Lower San Francisco Road carried passengers between San Francisco and San Jose on a nine-hour journey. The line was short lived: A stormy winter that flooded local roads and thieving drivers forced Whisman to sell his stage line in 1850.

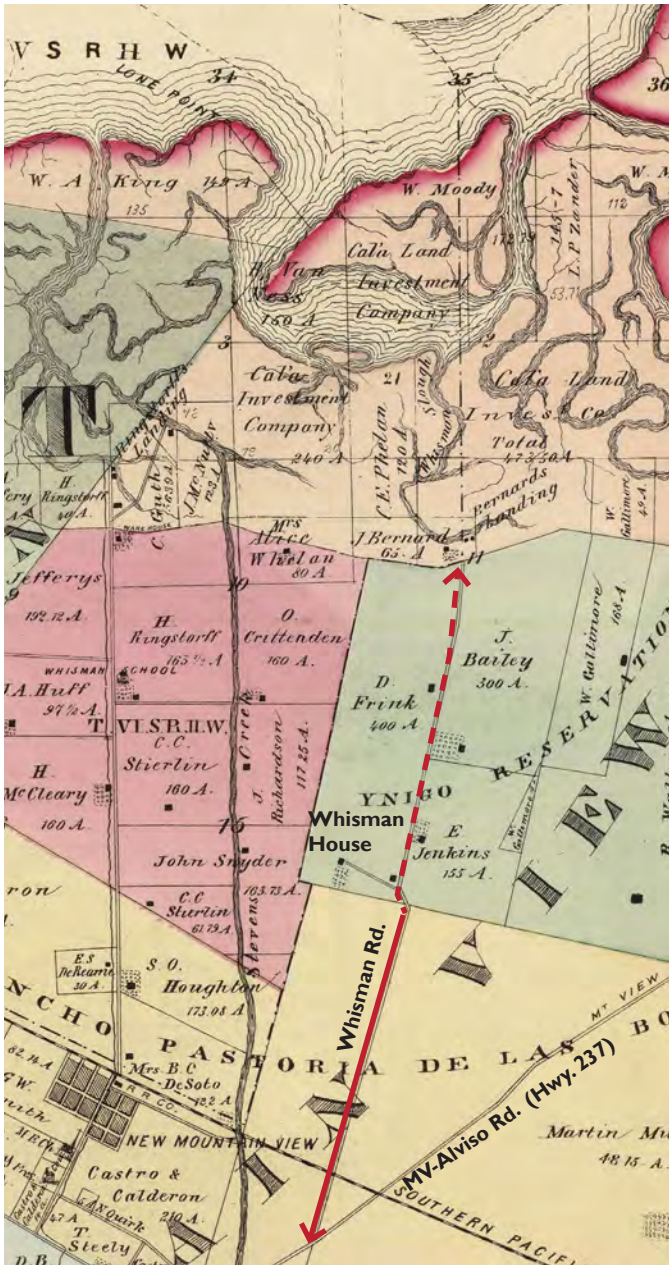
Today, three Mountain View streets carry the Whisman family name. The historic Whisman Road is one of the oldest streets in the area, and once connected the old Mtn. View-Alviso Road (Hwy 237) with landings on the San Francisco Bay. The road was cut to its present length when Moffett Field was built in 1933. Whisman Park Drive and Whisman Station Drive are two newer streets that lead to VTA's Whisman light rail station, which opened in 1999. In addition to these streets, two neighborhoods, North Whisman and Whisman Station, and the Mountain View-Whisman School District ensure that this early pioneer family's name is not forgotten.



WILLIGROVE INN ON THE SAN JOSE LOWER ROUTE.—The traveling public are respectfully informed that a House of Entertainment has been opened under the above name, on the Monterey route, via San Jose, for the reception of persons frequenting this important thoroughfare. The Table will be well supplied, the Bar amply furnished with choice Wines and Liquors; while the convenience and beauty of the locality—its excellent water and abundant pasturage, render it a desirable stopping place for those visiting the interior. The Inn is situated about forty miles from San Francisco, and twelve miles from the Pueblo de San Jose.

J. W. WHISMAN.

Advertisement for John W. Whisman's Willigrove Inn from the Oct. 25, 1848 "Alta California" newspaper.



When this 1876 map was published Whisman Road from Mtn. View-Alviso Road (Hwy. 237) through what is now Moffett Field and to the ship landings on the San Francisco Bay.



A c. 1950s MVHA historic sign near the NASA Ames Childcare Center marks the site of the Whisman house and Willowgrove Inn.

Special Remembrances

The MVHA is sad to share the news that we recently lost two of our Life Members, Edna Thompson and Austin Spencer. We extend our deepest sympathies to all their friends and family. Thank you to Edna's son, Charles Thompson, and Austin's daughter and MVHA web master, Suzette Spencer, for providing us with the stories shared below.



Above:
Edna and Stan Thompson volunteering for the MVHA at Shoreline Park in 1988.



Right:
Portrait of Edna from the 1951 Mtn. View High School yearbook, where she worked as Registrar.

Edna Birkett Thompson

April 7, 1920 – Dec. 5, 2015

Edna Birkett Thompson was born in Bootle, Liverpool, England on April 7, 1920. Wife of the late Stanley Thompson. She passed away on December 5, 2015, at the age of 95. Survived by her son, Charles Stanley Thompson.

She was raised in Liverpool, England; Vancouver, Canada; and San Francisco, California. She graduated from Frank McCoppen Elementary School in San Francisco. The family moved to their vacation home in Mountain View during the Depression. She graduated from Mountain View Union High School in 1937 and attended the San Francisco School of Business in San Francisco. She worked in several places in Mountain View; most memorable were the War Price and Rationing Board at 215 Castro Street, Mountain View as Chief Clerk; Mountain View Union High School as Secretary/Registrar; and Spangler Mortuary as Secretary.

Edna did volunteer work for numerous groups including the El Camino Hospital Auxiliary as a Charter Member and the Mountain View Historical Association as a Life Member. She worked each week for 15 years at the Mountain View Library History Center with her friend from High School, Barbara McPheeters Kinchen, City Historian.

Interment was next to her husband at Alta Mesa Cemetery, Palo Alto.





Above:
Austin Spencer c. 1930 in front of his family home on California St. after a duck hunt.

Right:
Austin Spencer in 1968

Austin George Spencer

Nov. 8, 1918 – Nov. 19, 2015

Austin George Spencer was born in Mountain View in 1918 to Herbert Joseph Spencer and Maud Louise Spencer, the youngest of their five children. In the early 1900s his family were merchants on Castro Street, owning McDonald and Burk Blacksmith and Mountain View Ice, where he worked as a boy.

Austin was a graduate of Santa Clara University. He retired from the Mountain View Branch of Wells Fargo Bank where he was an officer for 30 years. Austin was very active in the local community and was a member of the Palo Alto Elks, Mountain View Rotary, Mountain View Historical Association, and the Mountain View Chamber of Commerce where he served as President in 1968-69.

He died peacefully at his home in Mountain View on November 19, 2015, and his survived by his spouse, Eleanor, and his two daughters, Paulette and Suzette. He was 97. Donations in his memory may be made directly through Santa Clara University. If you have questions, please contact the Development Office at (408) 554-4400, 500 El Camino Real, Santa Clara, CA 95053-1400.

Message to Our Members

From the Mountain View Historical Association Board of Directors

Happy New Year to all our members! The year 2016 brings both new opportunities and new challenges for our organization as we approach our 62nd year. We want to take a moment to share some thouughts on the year ahead.

The Mountain View area is in a period of transition right now. Many long-time residents—the ones who tend to be most likely to participate in a local historical association—have moved away to places where their dollar goes further. This has made retaining and growing membership a constant challenge.

At the same time, the presence of our historical association here is perhaps more important now than ever. Mountain View has become a world-famous city due its role in shaping Silicon Valley. Our organization is uniquely positioned to chronicle the changes taking place as well as provide an important connection to the past, for both old-timers and newcomers alike. As we enter 2016, we could use your help to ensure our organization stays strong as Mountain View continues to evolve. Please read on to learn how.

Membership

Since the start of 2015, we've welcomed 26 new members to our organization, bringing us to 312 dues-paying members. We also have 970 people following us on online at www.facebook.com/MVHistory. We are working on ways of making it easier for people to join and renew membership online, so that more of those Facebook folks might join us in real life! In the meanwhile, here are some ideas for how you can help us continue to grow as an organization:

1. **Renew!** For those who pay annual membership dues, we hope you'll join us for 2016!

2. **Give the Gift of Membership.** Do you know someone who just moved to Mountain View? Or maybe someone who moved away but misses their hometown? Or maybe just a friend or relative fascinated by our city's history that's not a member? For any of those folks, a membership to the MVHA makes a great gift!

3. **Become a Lifetime Member.** If you plan on being a member for the long-haul, then consider becoming a lifetime member. You'll never have to worry about renewing again, and you lifetime membership fee will help us take on new projects and events.

Please use the form on page 7 to renew, gift, or upgrade your membership. Thank you for your membership!

Board of Directors Vacancies

After years of dedicated service, many of our Board members are ready to retire this year. This will leave an unprecedented number of open Board positions without incumbents seeking reelection or reappointment. Without new board members, our organization's long-term stability is at risk. We hope some of you reading this will seek to join the board and help the MVHA continue to grow and thrive. A variety of positions will be available and we can work with you to find one that matches your talents, interests, and availability.

The time commitment is small: four Board meetings a year, four events a year. A Nomination Committee will be appointed at our Summer BBQ on August 7, and elections will take place at our Fall meeting on November 6. If you're interested, please do not hesitate to let us know! nterested individuals are also encouraged to attend our upcoming Board meetings.

Volunteer Opportunities

The MVHA welcomes members interested in lending their time and talent. Below are some immediate needs:

Event Tabling: Greet the public at the MVHA's table at upcoming events. See Page 8 for upcoming events.

History Center: The Mountain View History Center on the second floor of the Mountain View Public Library is still looking for volunteers to join our team. Help us share Mountain View's historic archives with the public. With your help, we can offer longer hours and greater access to this invaluable resource.

We will gladly answer any questions you may have about membership, joining the Board, or volunteering. E-mail questions to info@mountainviewhistorical.org or call (650) 903 6890. Thank you for your consideration!

Membership

Membership Report

Submitted by June Casey
Membership Chair

Membership as of January 9, 2016

Honored Members	2
Life Members	112
Family Members	80
Single Members	118
TOTAL MEMBERSHIP	**312**

A warm welcome to our new members!

New Life Member: Garrett Hammell

New Members: Alex Andrade, Betty Cooper, Sam & Nancy Graham.



Faces of the MVHA

Our organization is nothing without its wonderful members! In this feature, we shine a spotlight on members who shared a bit about themselves at our most recent event.

Lucas Ramirez



Year joined: 2014

Connection to Mtn. View: I'm a lifelong resident, the current chair of the Mountain View Human Relations Commission, and a city council gadfly.

Favorite thing about the MVHA: I really enjoy the MVHA programs. There's so much about the history of the City that I know almost nothing about, and we are very fortunate to have such a thriving historical association!

Favorite spot in Mtn. View: I love City Hall. I attend most of the council meetings, and it has become something of a second home.



RENEW TODAY

If you had an Annual Membership in 2015, we hope you'll join us again in 2016. Dues are tax deductible to the extent allowed by law. NOTE: For new members who joined after May 2015, your membership carries forward through 2016. Thank you to all our members!

MVHA MEMBERSHIP FORM

The MVHA welcomes new members! By becoming a member, you are making a special investment in our mission to preserve and share Mountain View history with the community, conserve priceless archival materials at the History Center, and hold memorable public events throughout the year.
Please support the MVHA, and join us today!

- ☐ New Membership
- ☐ Membership Renewal
- ☐ Single Membership: *$15/year*
- ☐ Family Membership: *$25/year*
- ☐ Life Membership *$200*
- ☐ *I'm interested in volunteer opportunities*
- ☐ *This membership is being given as a gift*

Member Name(s): _____

Street Address: _____

City: _____

State: _____ Zip Code: _____

Telephone: _____

Email: _____

Please make checks payable to:
Mtn. View Historical Association

Mail to: Mtn. View Historical Association
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, Ca 94042

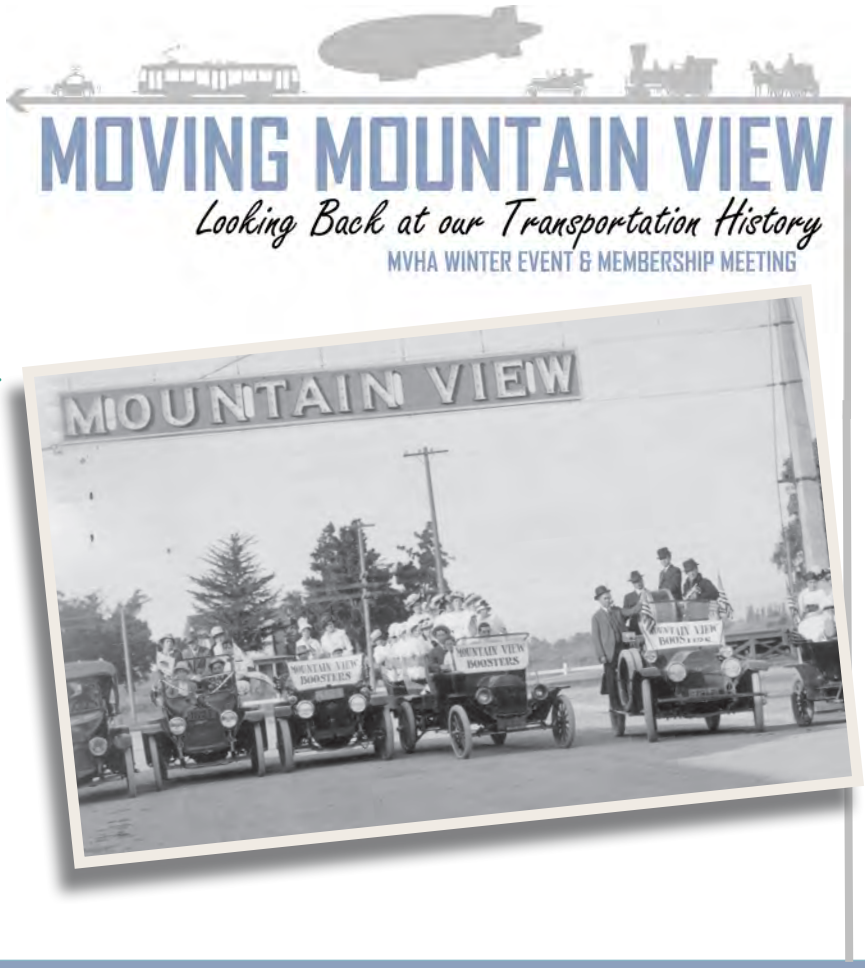
WINTER/SPRING

January 31
Sunday, 1:00-2:30 p.m.
MVHA Winter Event/Meeting
Adobe Building - 157 Moffett Blvd.
"Moving Mountain View" - Details on Page 1

March 9
Wednesday, 6:00-8:00 p.m.
MVHA Board Meeting
M.V. Library History Center, 585 Franklin St.
Interested members welcome to attend!

April 23
Saturday, 12:00-3:00 p.m.
Downtown Spring Parade
Castro Street - Downtown Mtn.View
MVHA volunteers needed!
E-mail info@mountainviewhistorical.org

May 1
Sunday, 1:00-2:30 p.m.
MVHA Spring Event/Meeting
Adobe Building - 157 Moffett Blvd.
More info. in our Spring newsletter!



EST. 1954
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Join us for another year of Mountain View history and renew your annual membership. Membership form on Page 7.

FIRST CLASS MAIL

Join the conversation on Facebook!
"Like" us at ***www.facebook.com/MVHistory*** for updates on MVHA Events, historic trivia, and to interact with other members on-line.

Save a tree and see the newsletter in:
Full Color
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